

Yoko Ono is a Japanese artist who specializes in multiple forms of expression. She specializes in conceptual multimedia representational art, and is most commonly known for her work “Cut Piece” and “Grapefruit”. She also happened to be Beatles member John Lennon’s wife, at the time he was assassinated. Yoko Ono’s work has been referenced as the opposite to artists such as Banksy, where everyone knows Banksy’s art but not Banksy themselves. Yoko Ono herself is a very famous public figure, but her work is extremely underappreciated and not very well known. Her work included beautiful demonstrations of lyricism, illustration, writing and composition. She is credited with being one of the key pioneers of modern conceptual art in the 1960’s, and her influence is seen widespread. Currently, Ono is still alive and still creating. She is a staunch political activist and uses her artwork to spread awareness and opinions. For example, after the 1999 Columbine shooting, she paid for multiple billboards in New York and LA depicting John Lennon’s broken and blood-spattered glasses, gruesomely depicting the widespread desensitization to mass shootings and murder. Her love for Lennon is a driving force in much of her work, and he was a muse and inspiration to her throughout their time together.

One piece of Yoko Ono’s I’d like to focus on is her book, “Grapefruit”. The book was written in 1964 and was part of the Fluxus movement of conceptual art in the form of writing and music production. The book contains a series of “event scores”, which are depictions of artistic representation written out as instructions or observations about a conceptual scene. Grapefruit is filled with colorful and moving imagery that is depicted through very few words, and yet it still manages to capture emotion and visual communication easily through Ono’s writing. Some of my favorite scores include “Painting to be Stepped On” (“Leave a piece of canvas or finished painting on the floor or in the street.”) and “Conversation Piece” (“Bandage a part of your body. If people ask about it, make a story and tell. If people do not ask about it, draw their attention to it and tell. If people forget about it, remind them of it and keep telling. Do not talk about anything else.”). The pieces convey meaningful scenes and powerful ideas through simple instructions, and I have studied them as well in my FFAR 249 class. I find her work to be personally inspiring and I hope in my field to come up with a clever way to modernize conceptual art and event scores in a way that suits an interactive medium.

